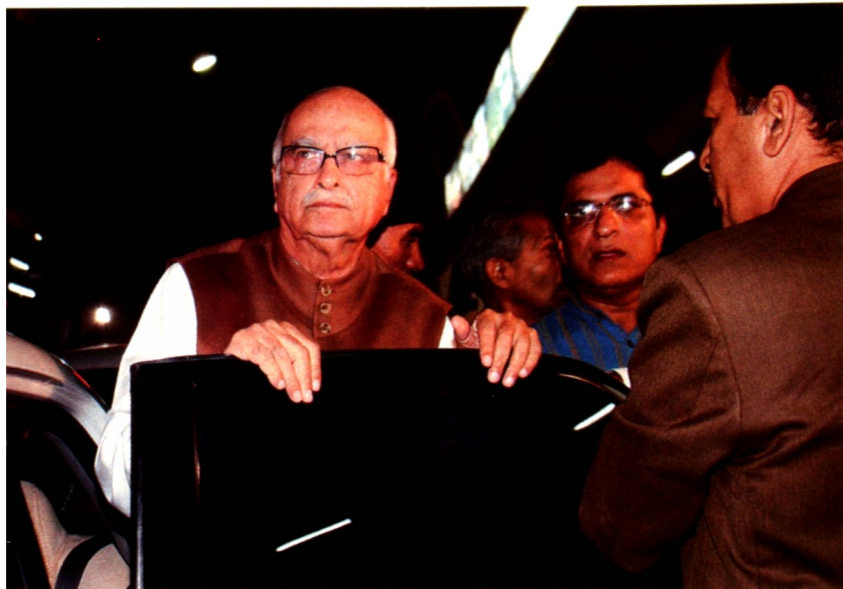


ADVANI AND MANMOHAN LOST A CHANCE TO SHOWCASE POLITICAL UNITY WHEN THEY WENT TO MUMBAI SEPARATELY.



ADVANI (ABOVE) AND MODI RUSH TO MUMBAI TO PLAY UP TO THEIR VOTEBANKS



REUTERS/STRINGER

leader said, "Earlier we faced flak on the price hike and terror. Now with the prime minister handling the economy and Chidambaram heading home, we get to win on both counts."

Currently the mood at the party headquarters is nowhere near the optimism which the party took to the Assembly polls early November. At that point the party was confident of winning Delhi, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh. Post-Mumbai, the party is only hopeful of Rajasthan. Gone are the talks of holding elections in February instead of April as scheduled. The party needs time to get its act together both on the economy and on security. In one stroke, the prime minister has lost whatever mileage he gained from the nuclear deal. Even before Mumbai, the Congress was wary of the electoral gains from the deal. Apart from Rahul, no other leader raised it during the

Assembly elections. However, the employment guarantee scheme and the farmers' loan waiver worked well. Expect more rhetoric on this and less on the nuke deal. And, of course, a lot more Pakistan-bashing.

The Congress may have its problems but the Opposition has not covered itself in glory either. The Naqvi episode opened the party to a barrage of criticism, with the BJP disowning his comments. Party General Secretary Arun Jaitley said, "Even as you express dissent on an issue, the language should be dignified. Naqvi's statement went beyond that."

The political damage went all the way to the top. Both the prime minister and leader of the Opposition L.K. Advani lost their chance to rise above politics and be seen as statesmen when they couldn't put up a show of political unity. It was an unhappy series of events that conspired to keep the two leaders from a joint visit to the terror-struck city. When Advani called up Manmohan late on 26 November to assure him of the BJP's support in a time of crisis, the prime minister proposed they travel together to Mumbai the next day. Advani, who had already cancelled the celebrations of his wife's birthday, agreed. The next day he was told by the Centre that it would be better to reschedule the visit since the operation wasn't over. Advani, committed to addressing public meetings in poll-bound Rajasthan, couldn't reschedule any more and proceeded to Mumbai on his own. Meanwhile, Manmohan was advised by senior Congress leaders that he too should visit the same day, lest the BJP leader steal the thunder. So he too went, and with Sonia. Advani then sought a rendezvous with the prime minister in Mumbai, but the offer was not responded to.

In the end, both leaders arrived on the same day but separately. By then, the public mood was so anti-politician that it was seen as just another example of political priorities and one-upmanship in the face of the gravest threat to the country in recent years. Whatever party they belonged to, last week was the day of the terrorist but the night of the ugly politician.

with Bhavna Vij-Aurora